

gscore

Sheet music anyone can open

Sébastien Tricaud · MIT licence · since 2001

June 2001

A man. A Linux box. GTK+. No plan to speak of.

The very first line of the changelog:

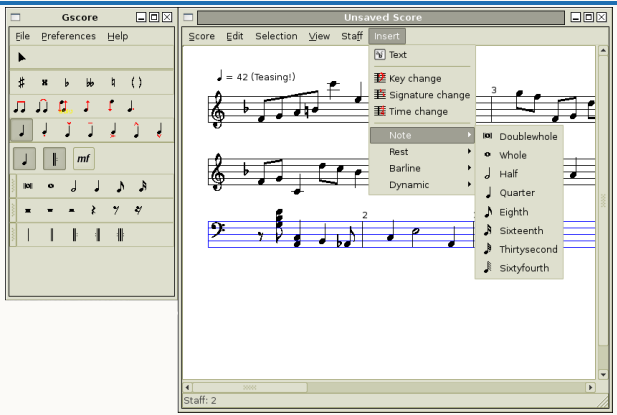
```
2001-06-03  toady

  * src/main.c:  You can exit the app using X-kill with a
       dialog asking you for the modifications you did
(arf!).
```

Four years and **15,627 lines of C** later, it could write music.



This is gscore 0.0.9, April 2005



A floating toolbox, because GIMP did it that way and GIMP was right.

Look closely at that screenshot

- The music runs on and on — **no pages, no page breaks**
- Because it was for *writing*, not for printing
- The tempo marking in the demo score reads **“♩ = 42 (Teasing!)”**
- Somebody was enjoying themselves

Twenty-one years later, that strip is still in there.
It is called **Continuous** and it is still the better way to write.

Releases had names, naturally

0.0.7 — **“bond”**

0.0.9 — **“harder, better, stronger, faster”**

```
* src/score.c:  Replace "set header" glade widget with a custom one
    to make the release in 2005 and
    stop fighting with glade for MDI stuff
```

Every programmer has written that commit.



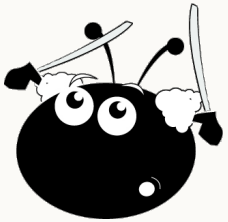
Then: twenty-one years of silence

- Mandrake packaged it in December 2004
- Mandriva kept packaging it
- **OpenMandriva still ships it today**
- Nobody told the maintainers to stop, so they did not

A program can outlive its own author's attention span.

2026: written again, from nothing

- Go instead of C
- SMuFL and Bravura instead of hand-drawn pixmaps
- Tests instead of hope
- The 2005 source kept intact as the specification
- **Gilbert survived the rewrite**



He was the splash screen.
He is now the bullet point.

Same idea. Same mascot. Rather better engraving.

So. You have written a piece.

Now send it to your flute player.

- "Install MuseScore first." — *half a gigabyte and an account*
- "Here's a PDF." — *now it is a picture*
- "It's on this website." — *adverts, login, link rot*
- "What on earth is a `.mscz`?" — *a fair question*

Writing the music was the *easy* part.

One file. Everyone can open it.

`badinerie.html`

- Double-click. It opens in **any browser ever made**
- The engraving, the music font and the player are **inside the file**
- No install. No server. No account. No network.
- Your phone. The work laptop nobody may install things on. 2036.

. . . and then it plays

- Press play *in the page*: it sounds, and the cursor follows along
- Slurs held, staccato short, dynamics where you put them
- Nothing downloads — the sound is in there too

You did not send a picture of a score.
You sent **the score**.

The file that is also a different file

`sonata.gscore`

↓ rename it

`sonata.pdf`

- A saved score carries a printed PDF of itself in front of it
- Renamed, it opens in anything that reads a PDF
- Opened in gscore, it is still the **editable score**

One file to keep. One file to send. They are the same file.

Parts your players will not complain about

- One PDF: the conductor's score, then every instrument behind it
- Score on its side if that is what holds it — **parts always upright**
- Each part set at a size readable from a stand, not from a microscope
- Each part named in its own margin, pages numbered *within itself*
- Seventeen staves too tall for the sheet? Divided **between staves**, evenly — never sliced off by the paper's edge

Writing music is typing

- ↑ ↓ move the note a step
- space write it
- enter a rest, same length
- ← → move along
- backspace undo your optimism
- b beam S slur = tie
- u d stem up, stem down
- . dot it
- shift+space play
- esc back to the top

Your hands never leave the keyboard. Neither does your attention.

The number row *is* the note value

1 whole	2 half	3 dotted half	4 quarter
5 dotted quarter	8 eighth	9 sixteenth	0 thirty-second

- Pick a length, type the tune, change the length, carry on
- On a drum staff the **letters type the kit** — a groove is typed, not clicked thirty-two times

Everywhere. And it is one file.

- **macOS** — a real Mac application, menu bar and all
- **Windows** — one `.exe`; put it anywhere, run it
- **Linux** — a `.deb`, or the same single binary
- **A web page** — the entire program compiled to WebAssembly. No server. Your music never leaves your machine.

The interface, the music font and the engraver all live inside the binary.
There is nothing to install beside it. There never was.

It opens what you already have

`.mscz` `.mscx`	*MuseScore, without MuseScore*
`.musicxml` `.xml` `.mxl`	*from anything at all*
`.nwc` `.nwctxt`	*NoteWorthy, without Windows*
`.abc`	*the entire folk archive*

Every importer reads *past* what it does not understand
and then tells you what it skipped.

A file is never refused whole.

And writes what everybody else reads

- **PDF** — print it
- **HTML** — send it
- **MusicXML** — anywhere
- **SVG** — into a document
- **MIDI** — into your DAW
- **FLAC** — a real recording
- **LilyPond** — for engraving even better than this

The LilyPond export is tested by *compiling it with LilyPond*. Saying “it looks like LilyPond” is not a claim worth making.

It sounds like actual instruments

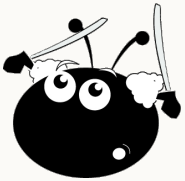
- Press play: you hear it *immediately* — no loading, no waiting
- Point it at a soundfont and it plays **real recorded instruments**
- The Mac and Windows downloads **already carry one**
- Export the whole score as FLAC, losslessly

One place in the program decides what the music sounds like, so the editor, the MIDI file and the recording cannot disagree.

Invent a mark. Send it to someone.

- Draw it, name it, put it on a note
- It **travels inside the file**, still attached to that note
- They open the score; the mark is there, and it still means something
- Share a whole set of them as a pack

Everywhere else, an invented mark arrives as
a *smudge floating near the music*.



One file. Anyone can open it.

`github.com/stricaud/gscore`

C and GTK+, 2001–2005. Go, 2026.
Gilbert, throughout.